

Covenant



A bride and groom face each other under a flowering arch, hands held. Vows, not a handshake deal. Joy, and a bond that is meant to hold.

OPTIONAL, THREE MINUTES

Before the icebreaker, three minutes. Which word from incarnation through covenant do you least want to forget, and why? One sentence. No speeches. Then open Genesis 15.

Before you gather

- Read Day 20, Covenant, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Genesis 15:7–18 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.
- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 · ICEBREAKER · 7 MIN

Open the room

What promise has someone kept long after it stopped being easy?

Leader. A kept promise. Then open Genesis 15. God walks the aisle alone. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 · THE WORD · 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: A covenant is God binding Himself to His people by promise. The new covenant stands because Jesus shed His blood. This was the plan all along.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

A covenant is a divinely established, binding relationship in which God commits Himself to His people with promises and often confirms it with signs and blood.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek *diathēkē* — a covenant, a binding commitment, a testament.

MEMORY VERSE · HEBREWS 9:15

Therefore he is the mediator of a new covenant, so that those who are called may receive the promised eternal inheritance, since a death has

occurred that redeems them from the transgressions committed under the first covenant.

Together, open the flashcard for Covenant. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 · OPEN THE BIBLE · 15 MIN

Genesis 15:7–18

Hebrews 9:15 is the memory verse. Stay in Genesis 15. Abraham does not march through the pieces. God commits Himself. Do not turn this into a lecture on every covenant in the Bible.

And he said to him, “I am the LORD who brought you out from Ur of the Chaldeans to give you this land to possess.” ... “Know for certain that your offspring will be sojourners... and they shall come back here.” When the sun had gone down and it was dark, behold, a smoking fire pot and a flaming torch passed between the pieces. On that day the LORD made a covenant with Abram, saying, “To your offspring I give this land.”

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. In Genesis 15, who passes between the pieces, and who is put to sleep? **CORE**

Leader. Abraham is asleep. A smoking fire pot and a flaming torch — God — pass between the pieces. God binds Himself. Abraham does not earn the promise.

2. What does God promise in the verses you read, and what does Abraham contribute?

Leader. Offspring, land, and God as his shield and reward. Abraham believes. He does not negotiate terms. Faith receives the promise.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Hebrews 9:15 says a death has occurred that redeems, so the called receive the promised eternal inheritance. Why was blood required?

Leader. A covenant with guilty people needs a death. Jesus is the mediator of a new covenant. Without the shedding of blood there is no forgiveness.

4. Luke 22:20: "This cup is the new covenant in my blood." What should we remember at the Lord's table? CORE

Leader. We proclaim His death. The cup is His blood, poured out. The new covenant stands because He died, not because we are reliable. Jesus came to die.

5. Jeremiah 31:33–34. God says "I will." Which of His promises do we live as if He might take back?

Leader. He will write His law on hearts, be their God, and remember their sin no more. The new covenant is God's "I will," not our "we might."

5 · SAY IT · 5 MIN

In one sentence

A covenant is God binding Himself by promise, and the new covenant stands because Jesus died.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 · THIS WEEK · 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Keep a real promise this week to someone who has been let down, especially if they do not trust Christians. Tell them God binds Himself by

promise, and the new covenant stands because Jesus shed His blood.

Leader. "I'll pray for you" does not count unless you also do the thing you promised. The sentence is about God's promise, not about how dependable you are. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 · PRAY · 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Faithful God, thank You for promises that do not rest on us.
2. Forgive us for breaking our word and then doubting Yours.
3. Help us keep one promise this week, and to point to the blood of the new covenant.

Before you stumble

Do not flatten every covenant into the same terms. In Genesis 15, God walks alone. Sinai will include commands. The new covenant fulfills both: law on the heart, and a death that secures the inheritance. If the room is new, you need this: God commits Himself, and Jesus' blood is why we inherit. Do not end on Abraham. End on the cup.

WITH STUDENTS

Ask what happens to a group project when only one person is reliable. Then ask why it is good news that God passed through the pieces alone.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Luke 22:20 again, out loud, if you have one minute. "This cup that is poured out for you is the new covenant in my blood." Then pray.